CONTENT SYSTEMS.AI

Turn 1 SOP into an AI skill

The order I do it in, the fill-in template I use, and a worked example. About 20 minutes for your first 1.

Why it's worth writing now

AI TOOLS THAT READ SKILLS

70+

Including ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot and Cursor, now that skills are an open standard.[1]

SKILLS PUBLISHED

1M

Published so far under the open standard.[1]

INSTALLS, NEARLY

280M

Reported by Anthropic on Oct 22 2026.[1]

1 Anthropic, Oct 22 2026, Agent Skills donated to the Linux Foundation's Agentic AI Foundation, anthropic.com/news/donating-agent-skills-to-the-agentic-ai-foundation

The 20-minute order

0 TO 3 MIN

Pick 1 thing you repeat every week.

3 TO 8

Write it like you're training a new hire.

8 TO 13

Add 3 real examples of it done well.

13 TO 16

Mark where it needs your yes.

16 TO 20

Test it on last week's work.

A skill is an SOP written for an AI instead of a new hire.

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01 The template

THE BASICS

A skill is a folder named after the job, with this file inside, called SKILL.md. Add your 3 examples to the same folder.

THE 2 LINES THAT MATTER MOST

The name and the description at the top. The AI reads the description to decide when to use the skill, so say what it does and when.

NO SKILLS SUPPORT?

Paste the same text into a project's instructions in any AI chat tool. It still works.

> YOU APPROVE
>
> Anything it sends, buys, posts or deletes. Write that down in Rules, every time.

SKILL.MD — FILL IN THE BRACKETS

```
---
name: [job-name-in-lowercase]
description: [What it does, in 1 sentence.
  Use when [the moment someone needs it].]
---

# [Job name]

## What it's for
[1 line: the outcome, and who it's for.]

## Before you start
[What you need: the files, notes or
 numbers it should ask for if missing.]

## Steps
1. [1 action per step, plain words]
2. [...]
3. [...]

## Rules
- Needs my yes before: [sending, paying,
  posting, deleting]
- Never: [promise a date, price or refund]
- If unsure: write [ASK ME], don't guess

## Done looks like
[How you'd know it's right at a glance.]

## Examples
See the 3 examples in this folder.
```

02 Writing tips that save a rewrite

A Start from what you did

Talk through the task out loud while you do it. Turn the transcript into steps.

B 1 job per skill

If the steps split into 2 jobs, make 2 skills. Short skills fail less.

C Examples beat adjectives

"Friendly but brief" means nothing. 3 real emails you sent mean everything.

D Fix the skill, not the output

When it gets something wrong, add 1 line to the skill so it can't happen again.

03 A worked example

THE SOP IT CAME FROM

The weekly client update email. Same shape every Friday, about 30 minutes to write by hand.

ITS 3 EXAMPLES

The 3 best updates sent last month, pasted in as files, names removed.

TIME NOW

About 5 minutes: paste in the week's notes, read the draft, fix 1 or 2 lines, send.

> **YOU APPROVE**
> Every email before it goes. It drafts, it never sends.

SKILL.MD — **WEEKLY-CLIENT-UPDATE**

```
---
name: weekly-client-update
description: Drafts the Friday update email to a
  client from my notes. Use when I paste a
  week's notes and say "client update".
---
# Weekly client update
## What it's for
A short Friday email so the client knows
where things stand without a call.
## Before you start
Ask for: client name, this week's notes,
next week's plan. If any is missing, ask.
## Steps
1. List what got done, as 3 to 5 bullets
2. Flag anything late, with the new date
3. Say what happens next week
4. End with 1 question that needs their input
## Rules
- Needs my yes before: sending anything
- Never: promise a date not in my notes
- If unsure: write [ASK ME]
## Done looks like
Under 150 words. Readable on a phone.
## Examples
See the 3 examples in this folder.
```

Test it on last week before you trust it

- [ ] Run it on last week's notes and put its draft next to the email you actually sent.
- [ ] Every difference that matters becomes 1 new line in the skill.
- [ ] Run it again. When 2 drafts in a row need no real fixes, it's ready for this week.

Want the next 1?

I share the skills I build and the AI news worth your time, every week, in plain words. Follow along, and comment AI on any of my posts for the AI Employee Starter Pack: 5 ready-to-paste skills plus the permission sheet.

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